BROUGHT TO BOOK

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"This has got to stop immediately," Justice Mathematics said in a stern voice, rapping the hammer for silence in the court.

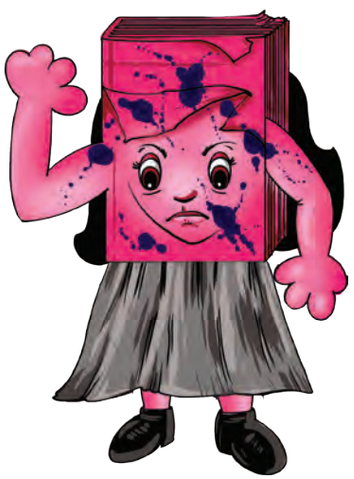
He pushed back the horn-rimmed glasses up his nose and glared first at Mahesh and then at the crowd in the court. Everybody respected him, even Mahesh, so a pin-drop silence fell in the court instantly.

"Let us proceed," Justice Mathematics said nodding his head.

"Your witness, first," he gestured at the torn Ms. English.

Mahesh chewed his nails nervously.

"Your Honour," began the lady, in a trembling voice, "when I came to this house, I wore a lovely pink and grey dress, shiny and unmarked. And, Sir, just look at me now."



Everybody gazed at her. Her dress was unrecognizable. Covered with ink and grease spots, mercilessly dog-eared and two corners chewed away, she looked a **wreck**. Tears rolled down Ms. English's cheeks.

Offering her a handkerchief, Justice Mathematics asked gently, "How did it happen, Ms. English?"

"Well," sniffed Ms. English, "this boy," she pointed at Mahesh, "brought me home a few months back but never bothered to cover me properly with the nice brown paper his father had brought."

"Did Mahesh not get scolded and punished in school for that?" Justice Mathematics enquired.

"Oh, yes, he was, repeatedly," said Ms. English in a tearful voice, "but all the punishment and scolding slipped off him like water off a duck's back!Not only did he ruin my looks," she continued, "he also ill-treated me."

The audience was stunned, ill-treating a delicate creature like Ms. English! How terrible! By now tears had started rolling down Ms. English's big eyes. And stopping only to sniff delicately in her handkerchief, she told everyone about how Mahesh dropped her carelessly, stuffed her anyhow in his crammed bag, sometimes next to the lunch box dripping with oil! Mahesh turned red as many pairs of eyes glared at him. Oh! Why had he not listened to his mother, who had told him many times to take care of his books! He was otherwise a good boy and even managed to stay within the first five ranks inclass. But he was extremely lazy.

"Mahesh!" the **stentorian** voice of Justice Mathematics brought him back to reality. "What do you have to say for yourself?"

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